keystone of the Mughal state's legitimacy and its posthumous legacy'. Long after the last Mughal died forlorn in Rangoon, the Akbar and the Mughal empire of Abul Fazl's book have lived on in the Indian imagination, surviving assaults from every front – not because Abul Fazl valorizes the perfection of one man, but rather because he locates that perfection in the fragile hope of peace for all, a phrase that echoes in the guiding tenet of the Indian dream, once familiar to every Indian schoolchild: unity in diversity.

~

In Jaunpur, young Banarasidas, budding poet, fell unconscious when he heard that Akbar had died. He was sitting on a staircase when 'The news struck him like a blow upon the heart'. Banarasi fainted and fell; 'He cracked his head and began bleeding profusely. / The word "God" slipped from his mouth.'[16]

His parents were frantic, Banarasi's mother ran to put burnt cloth to his wound. Outside, meanwhile, the whole city was experiencing Banarasi's shock and his parents' panic. 'The people, bereft of their emperor, felt orphaned and helpless,' the jeweller's son wrote later. 'The townsfolk were afraid, / Their hearts troubled, their faces pale with fear.'

Riots broke out and the town shut down. Worried about robberies and insurrections, people locked up their houses and shops, buried their fine clothes and jewels, accounting books and cash. Men put on rough blankets, 'The women too began to dress plainly.'

As it happens, there was no need to fear. 'No thieves or robbers were to be seen anywhere, / People were needlessly afraid.' Peace returned; 'A letter came from Agra saying that all was well' – announcing Salim's accession.

So often while Akbar lived – when he had his epileptic epiphany in Punjab, when he got off his horse during a polo match – rumours of his death or ill health had led to immediate revolts in the more restless pockets of his empire. And yet, so strong was the scaffolding on which Akbar had built his realm that when the emperor did die, his own mighty death did not shake it.

One man, however, was shaken to the core. Banarasi recovered from his wound. Like the rest of Jaunpur, he breathed in relief as the letter announcing Salim's peaceful succession 'was read from house to house'.